

Running head: Successful African American professionals

Interpretive Narrative

Successful African American professionals

Jim Pham

December 04, 2007

Interpretation Narrative

John, an African American man from Nigeria, was born in the late 60s in New Orleans, Louisiana, where he lived with his parents. Both of John's parents were from Nigeria. John's father worked as a dentist and a university lecturer, and his mother also worked as a university lecturer. Both of John's parents were very well educated. His mother had a Ph.D. John had four siblings—2 brothers and two sisters—who also live in the United States. Both of his sisters live in San Diego, and his two brothers live in the Atlanta area. Both of his brothers were medical doctors. John is married to an African American native of New Orleans. They had been together for seventeen years and had two sons. John's 10-year-old son attended a private elementary school, and his 3-year-old son attended a nearby daycare. John's highest educational level was a master's degree in engineering, and his wife had a bachelor's degree in accounting. John and his family owned a home in an upscale neighborhood in San Jose.

John and his parents moved to Nigeria when he was a young boy, and he spent most of his early childhood and adulthood there. John's parents enrolled him in a boarding school, and from then on, he attended college. As John stated, in his early days at boarding school, he had to study hard, work hard, and be responsible because that was expected and the norm for all students there. Having lived alone, away from his family, he was forced to take care of himself and become independent and responsible for his well-being. John was always a good student and ready for the next day's class work. Regarding academic achievement, John stated that “anything below a 3.5 GPA is a low grade.”

John started out in college, majoring in political science. Back then, John wanted to be a lawyer, but his plan fell through due to political turmoil in Nigeria and a military takeover. He finished his undergraduate studies and moved back to New Orleans, Louisiana. He did not want to be a dentist like his father or a university lecturer like his mother. He had an aptitude for the medical field, but he did not like to deal with blood, he said. John was inspired by his uncle, an aeronautical engineer, leading him to change his major from political science to statistics and engineering. Majoring in engineering was a natural fit for John because he had a high aptitude for math and science

He attended the University of New Orleans. While attending there, John met his wife. John and his wife both graduated from the University of New Orleans. John received a master's degree in engineering, and his wife received a bachelor's degree in accounting.

John started his career at IBM and worked there for about 10 years. John acquired knowledge in DB2 Mainframe and Operating System at IBM. While working for IBM, John attended Santa Clara University for an MBA. John did not finish school because he could not find a way to finance it. Five years ago, John went to work for Oracle Corporation as a Principles Application Engineer, specializing in OS, Linux, and DB2 Mainframe. At present, John still works for Oracle.

Even though John was an African American from Nigeria, he identified himself as an African American in this country. As John stated, most Nigerians who came to this country are highly educated, and Nigerian society was strongly influenced by the British educational system and missionaries. John goes on to say that Nigerians came to this country, particularly as married people with social or academic status, so they blended

into the middle-class culture. The differences between African Americans in this country and African Americans from Nigeria were significant, according to John. One interesting point made by John was that African Americans here in this country were descended from slavery. As a result, many African Americans did not get the opportunity or chance to be successful because of their placement in society. Whereas being an African American from Nigeria, John and his family, like many other immigrants from other countries, were well educated before they came to this country. Like many other ethnic groups who came to this country, they had strong family bonds and values, worked hard, valued education, and believed in education to advance their career and create a better life for themselves.

Regarding professionalism, John stated that education alone is not enough to determine professional qualification. He goes on to say that the purpose of education is to prepare a person for problem-solving and real-world issues, as well as for dealing with and working with other people and their backgrounds. As John stated, a professional is someone who has integrity, stands by what he/she does, takes responsibility, and is accountable.

All in all, John was a very successful person, and race was not a factor. In terms of wealth, I live in a house in Evergreen Hill. According to various studies, the house you live in ranks among the top 10% of homes in the valley. Looking at the percentage of African Americans in Silicon Valley, he was in the single digits. Based on the highest level of education completed, John was about average in the area near his home. In terms of professionalism, John was well versed in all areas such as education, good work ethic, being conscious of himself and others, taking responsibility and accountability, etc.

Based on the interviews, John was a very successful person, and not only was he an African American; he also had the true characteristics of a good person.

What themes have emerged from the interviews?

Many themes emerged from the interviews, including family, society, slavery, African Americans in this country, old-fashioned hard work, education, personal interests, and professionalism (responsibility and accountability). All of these themes pretty much describe any successful person, not just an African American

What evidence supports these themes?

In a personal and short narrative story about John and his family, and his journey from Nigeria to the United States, there were many themes that supported the person who wants to be successful, such as family bonds and family values, educational beliefs, old-fashioned hard work, living by the rules, and professionalism. From the interviews, it was clear that family bonds and values, educational beliefs, and hard work played a significant role in John's success. In the second interview, John talked about how his 10-year-old wanted to be a medical doctor. He stated that “he has no excuse and he wants to tell me that he wants to be a doctor ... if he is not taking school seriously ... you can’t be a doctor if you have a bad grade in science.” He is basically saying that his son has no excuse whatsoever for being sloppy in his academic work. John used his siblings, who are working in elite professions—medical doctors and educators. It is clear that John believes in the value of education and in ways to build a better future. Another example from the third interview: John mentioned that his family gets together once a year; they will meet in the Atlanta area to celebrate Thanksgiving and his dad's 70th birthday. This clearly showed that John has strong family bonds.

How did my observations contribute to uncovering these themes?

From the short narrative story above, many themes emerged that connected “success” to family history, such as early childhood to adulthood, family, and education, that contributed to the path to accomplishment and success. Regardless of race, if you want to achieve success in your career and life, you have to find a way to get there. It is clear that education is a way to get there.

How are these themes similar to any literature I have read?

John gave me a recent article from the San Jose Mercury News (2007), “Is it tougher for African Americans?” and asked me to read it. In one section, it discussed how a successful African American person is happy to help another African American in the workplace. Pamela Jackson said, “You are happy to see another African American...because it’s so rare.” Another statement by Rick Callender stated that “The only way you can relate to the African American community is...in church.” In the first interview, John repeatedly stated that he identified as African American and was proud of his accomplishments and his identity. He also talked about a recently African American who moved into the neighborhood near his home. He was proud to see another successful African American in that regard. Just so happens that this new African American, the dad was a football player for the San Francisco 49ers. Another example from the first interview, John talked about bringing his son to work. His 8-year-old son asked him, “Who are your friends?” John responded that “I have friends here, here, there, and there.” His son continued to ask, “How come you don't have any black friends at work?” This clearly shows that, in the workplace, African Americans rarely see another successful African American, especially in high-tech.

How have my feelings and beliefs about the topic changed/evolved/been reinforced by my participation in the fieldwork project?

As I have stated in my proposal, in my 15 years in the field of engineering, I have seen only a handful of African Americans in my workplace. Prior to my participation in this fieldwork project, I could not understand why African Americans as a group did not assimilate well into the American way of life. I have always been afraid of African Americans because of all the violence in the African American community (e.g., New Orleans, Oakland, and San Francisco). That was just a perception, and it was wrong. Now I come to learn more about African American culture and ways of life, and to appreciate their culture and values. I am now seeing other African Americans in John's eyes.